

PSC318: TECHNOLOGY, POLITICS, AND ENVIRONMENT

Fall 2026

Instructor:	Prof. Takumi Shibaike
Email:	tshibaik@syr.edu
Time:	3:45-5:05 PM, Monday & Wednesday
Location:	School of Management 011
Office Hours:	Wednesday 12:00-2:00 PM via youcanbook.me

1 Course Description

Global environmental problems, such as climate change, marine resource depletion, and species extinction, demand collaboration beyond national borders. In this course, we examine how the international community has attempted to address these challenges—and, crucially, why these efforts have so often fallen short. Students will engage key social scientific theories to analyze both past and present efforts to govern global environmental problems. Drawing on a wide range of actors (including but not limited to states, international organizations, scientific communities, corporations, indigenous peoples, and NGOs), the course equips students with the analytical tools to understand real-world environmental governance from multiple perspectives.

2 Shared Competency Categories

Civic and Global Responsibility; Critical and Creative Thinking

3 Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, you should be able to do the following:

- Understand major challenges to global environmental governance.
- Evaluate the roles of states, international organizations, corporations, NGOs, Indigenous peoples, and scientific communities in addressing global environmental issues.
- Critically reflect on how your own life relates to environmental protection as well as degradation.
- Work collaboratively to develop and communicate ideas for addressing contemporary environmental problems.

4 Assessment

4.1 Schedule and Weighting

Participation	10%
Quizzes	40% (best 2 of 3 quizzes)
Group Pact	5%
CoP Participation	5%
Position Paper	20%
Reflection Paper	20%

Attendance

You are expected to attend every meeting. The use of laptops is strongly discouraged during meetings, and the use of phones is strictly prohibited. Absence without notification will negatively affect your participation grade. *Absence from either of the CoP Meetings without appropriate documentation will result in a zero-grade for CoP participation.*

Absence

You may take absence from class with valid reasons. *You must notify the instructor prior to the class* in order to avoid penalties on your participation grade. You may be required to provide documentation.

Extension

You must notify the instructor prior to the deadline to avoid late penalties for each assignment. Keep in mind that you may be required to provide documentation.

Quizzes

Mini-exams will be held in person on **September 14, September 28, and October 7**. *Unless you provide official documentation for an excused absence, you may not take the exam at another time.* Disregard the final exam date shown in MySlice.

Zoom policy

When our class is held on Zoom, you must join using a laptop or desktop computer. Phones should not be used for Zoom participation, as they limit your ability to fully engage in class exercises.

Academic freedom

In order to ensure academic freedom in classroom, you must maintain confidentiality of who said what in discussions. Do not distribute course materials outside the class without the instructor's written per-

mission.

5 Assignments

You are expected to read (or occasionally listen to) the assigned materials prior to each meeting. Articles and book chapters are available online through SU Library resources. *All required readings are linked to the SU Library so that you can access and download them directly.*

6 Class Schedule

6.1 August 24: Welcome!

This syllabus.

Theoretical Foundations

6.2 August 26: How do we solve global environmental problems?

Freakonomics Radio. “The Simple Economics of Saving the Amazon Rain Forest.” (July 29, 2020).
<https://freakonomics.com/podcast/the-simple-economics-of-saving-the-amazon-rain-forest-ep-428/>

6.3 August 31: What is the environment?

Hardin, Garrett. “[The Tragedy of the Commons](#).” *Science* 162.3859 (1968): 1243–1248.

6.4 September 2: What is liberal environmentalism?

Bernstein, Steven. “[Ideas, social structure and the compromise of liberal environmentalism](#).” *European journal of International Relations* 6.4 (2000): 464–512.

6.5 September 7: Labour Day

6.6 September 9: How do we govern the environment?

United Nations Climate Change. “Clean Development Mechanism.” <https://unfccc.int/process-and-meetings/the-kyoto-protocol/mechanisms-under-the-kyoto-protocol/the-clean-development-mechanism>

Kainou, Kazunari. “Collapse of the Clean Development Mechanism scheme under the Kyoto Protocol and its spillover: Consequences of ‘carbon panic’.” (March 16, 2022).
<https://cepr.org/voxeu/columns/collapse-clean-development-mechanism-scheme-under-kyoto-protocol-and-its-spillover>

6.7 September 14: Exam 1

Bring your laptop!

6.8 September 16: How do international organizations govern the environment?

Raustiala, Kal, and David G. Victor. “[The regime complex for plant genetic resources.](#)” *International Organization* (2004): 277–309.

6.9 September 21: Are all international organizations equal?

Cochrane, Kevern. “[Use and misuse of CITES as a management tool for commercially-exploited aquatic species.](#)” *Marine Policy* 59 (2015): 16-31.

6.10 September 23: Who controls international organizations?

Nielson, Daniel L., and Michael J. Tierney. “[Delegation to international organizations: Agency theory and World Bank environmental reform.](#)” *International Organization* 57 (2003): 241-276.

6.11 September 28: Exam 2

Bring your laptop!

6.12 September 30: Will nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) save us?

NPR. “Is Sustainable-Labeled Seafood Really Sustainable?” <https://www.npr.org/2013/02/11/171376509/is-sustainable-labeled-seafood-really-sustainable>. (February 11, 2013).

6.13 October 5: What is the role of NGOs in global environmental governance?

Wapner, Paul. “[Politics beyond the state environmental activism and world civic politics.](#)” *World Politics* 47.3 (1995): 311–340.

Stroup, Sarah S., and Wendy H. Wong. “[Authority, strategy, and influence: Environmental INGOs in comparative perspective.](#)” *Environmental Politics* 27.6 (2018): 1101–1121.

6.14 October 7: Exam 3

Bring your laptop!

6.15 October 12: Fall break

Key Environmental Issues

6.16 October 14: How do we protect biodiversity?

Gehring, Thomas, and Eva Ruffing. “[When arguments prevail over power: the CITES procedure for the listing of endangered species.](#)” *Global Environmental Politics* 8.2 (2008): 123-148.

6.17 October 19: Why is it so hard to protect biodiversity?

Mace, Georgina M. “[Whose conservation?.](#)” *Science* 345.6204 (2014): 1558-1560.

Soule, Michael. “[The “New Conservation”.](#)” *Conservation Biology* 27.5 (2013): 895-897.

6.18 October 21: Why is it so hard to stop climate change?

We will review CITES CoP Meeting Proposals.

Keohane, Robert O., and David G. Victor. “[The regime complex for climate change.](#)” *Perspectives on Politics* (2011): 7-23.

Jinnah, Sikina. “[Climate change bandwagoning: The impacts of strategic linkages on regime design, maintenance, and death.](#)” *Global Environmental Politics* 11.3 (2011): 1-9.

6.19 October 26: Group Making

Work on and finalize your Group Pact during class.

Due: Group Pact, 5:05 PM, October 26

6.20 October 28: Is it all about domestic politics after all?

Allan, Jen Iris. “[Dangerous incrementalism of the Paris Agreement.](#)” *Global Environmental Politics* 19.1 (2019): 4-11.

Aklin, Michaël, and Matto Mildenberger. “[Prisoners of the wrong dilemma: Why distributive conflict, not collective action, characterizes the politics of climate change.](#)” *Global Environmental Politics* 20.4 (2020): 4-27.

6.21 November 2: What is climate justice and why is it important?

Bäckstrand, Karin, and Eva Lövbrand. “[The road to Paris: Contending climate governance discourses in the post-Copenhagen era.](#)” *Journal of Environmental Policy & Planning* 21.5 (2019): 519-532.

6.22 November 4: Are we giving up on international institutions?

de Moor, Joost. “Alternative Globalities? Climatization Processes and the Climate Movement Beyond COPs.” *International Politics* 58.4 (2021): 582-99.

6.23 November 9: Does the market mechanism work?

Mah, Alice. “Future-proofing capitalism: The paradox of the circular economy for plastics.” *Global Environmental Politics* 21.2 (2021): 121-142.

6.24 November 11: Whales—what are they?

Hurd, Ian. “Almost saving whales: the ambiguity of success at the International Whaling Commission.” *Ethics & International Affairs* 26.1 (2012): 103-112.

6.25 November 16: Strategizing Session

This is the last opportunity to work on your group’s position paper. You should also seek endorsements from other groups to the extent that such endorsements strengthen your position.

Due: Position Paper, 11:59 PM, November 16

6.26 November 18: No Class

Watch a recent CITES CoP Meeting: <https://www.youtube.com/live/c8SHsxjGSDo?si=hVAaYnxnKuKohJkw>. As you watch, pay attention to standard diplomatic and procedural practices. For example, delegates typically begin their interventions with phrases such as “Thank you, Chair” and refer to themselves as the entity they represent (e.g., “the United States” rather than “I”). Familiarizing yourself with these conventions will help you participate effectively in our simulated CoP meetings and avoid procedural corrections from the Chair.

6.27 November 23, 25: Thanksgiving break

6.28 November 30: CITES CoP Meeting 1

We will discuss the proposal listed in the agenda.

6.29 December 2: CITES CoP Meeting 2

We will discuss the proposal listed in the agenda.

6.30 December 7: No Class

Work on your CITES CoP reflection paper.

Due: Reflection Paper, 11:59 PM, December 7

7 University Policy

7.1 Academic Integrity

Syracuse University's [Academic Integrity Policy](#) reflects the high value that we, as a university community, place on honesty in academic work. The policy holds students accountable for the integrity of all work they submit and for upholding course-specific, as well as university-wide, academic integrity expectations. The policy governs citation and use of sources, the integrity of work submitted in exams and assignments, and truthfulness in all academic matters, including course attendance and participation.

The policy states that any work a student submits for a course must be solely their own unless the instructor explicitly allows collaboration or editing. The policy also requires students to acknowledge their use of other peoples' language, images or other original creative or scholarly work through appropriate citation. These expectations extend to the new, fast-growing realm of artificial intelligence (AI) as well as to the use of websites that charge fees or require uploading of course materials to obtain exam solutions or assignments. Students are required to ask their instructor whether use of these tools is permitted—and if so, to what extent—before using them to complete any assignment or exam. Students are also required to seek advance permission from instructors if they wish to submit the same work in more than one course. Failure to receive this permission in advance may violate the [Academic Integrity Policy](#). Under the policy, instructors who seek to penalize a student for a suspected violation must first report the violation to the Center for Learning and Student Success (CLASS). Students may not drop or withdraw from courses in which they face a suspected violation. Instructors must wait to assign a final course grade until a suspected violation is reviewed and upheld or overturned.

Upholding Academic Integrity includes abiding by instructors' individual course expectations, which may include the protection of their intellectual property. Students should not upload, distribute, or otherwise share instructors' course materials without permission. Students found in violation of the policy are subject to grade sanctions determined by the course instructor and non-grade sanctions determined by the School or College where the course is offered, as outlined in the [Violation and Sanction Classification Rubric](#). Students are required to read an online summary of the University's academic integrity expectations and provide an electronic signature agreeing to abide by them twice a year during pre-term check-in on MySlice.

The [Violation and Sanction Classification Rubric](#) establishes recommended guidelines for the determination of grade penalties by faculty and instructors, while also giving them discretion to select the grade penalty they believe most suitable, including course failure, regardless of violation level. Any established violation in this course may result in course failure regardless of violation level.

7.2 No-recording and No-sharing Policy

This course strictly prohibits any unauthorized audio and/or video recording, in whole or in part, of any lecture or discussion section. In addition, course materials provided by instructors must not be distributed or otherwise shared without permission. Violations will be handled through Syracuse University's Academic Integrity Policy.

7.3 AI Policy

All generative-AI tools are prohibited in this course because their use inhibits achievement of the course learning objectives. This policy applies to all stages of project and writing processes including researching, brainstorming, outlining, organizing, and polishing. Do not use Generative-AI tools to create any content (i.e., images and video, audio, text, code, etc.). If you have any questions about a feature and whether it is considered Generative-AI, ask your instructor.

7.4 Attendance

Attendance in classes is expected in all courses at Syracuse University. It is a federal requirement that faculty promptly notify the university of students who do not attend or cease to attend any class. Faculty will use Early-Semester Progress Reports and Mid-Semester Progress Reports in Orange SUccess to alert the Registrar and Financial Aid Office on [non-attendance](#).

7.5 Disability

Syracuse University values diversity and inclusion; we are committed to a climate of mutual respect and full participation. There may be aspects of the instruction or design of this course that result in barriers to your inclusion and full participation in this course. I invite any student to contact me to discuss strategies and/or accommodations (academic adjustments) that may be essential to your success and to collaborate with the Center for Disability Resources (CDR) in this process.

If you would like to discuss disability-accommodations or register with CDR, please visit Center for Disability Resources. Please call (315) 443-4498 or email disabilityresources@syr.edu for more detailed information.

7.6 Discrimination or Harassment

Federal and state law, and University policy prohibit discrimination and harassment based on sex or gender (including sexual harassment, sexual assault, domestic/dating violence, stalking, sexual exploitation, and retaliation). If a student has been harassed or assaulted, they can obtain confidential counseling support, 24-hours a day, 7 days a week, from the [Sexual and Relationship Violence Response Team](#) at the Counseling Center (315-443-8000, Barnes Center at The Arch, 150 Sims Drive, Syracuse, New York 13244). Incidents of sexual violence or harassment can be reported non-confidentially to the University's Title IX Officer (Sheila Johnson Willis, 315-443-0211, titleix@syr.edu, 005 Steele Hall). Reports to law enforcement can be made to the University's Department of Public Safety (315-443-2224, 005 Sims Hall), the Syracuse Police Department (511 South State Street, Syracuse, New York, 911 in case of emergency or 315-435-3016 to speak with the Abused Persons Unit), or the State Police (844-845-7269). I will seek to keep information you share with me private to the greatest extent possible, but as a professor I have mandatory reporting responsibilities to share information regarding sexual misconduct, harassment, and crimes I learn about with the University's Title IX Officer to help make our campus a safer place for all.

7.7 Religious Observances

Syracuse University's [Religious Observances Policy](#) recognizes the diversity of faiths represented in the campus community and protects the rights of students, faculty, and staff to observe religious holy days according to their traditions. Under the policy, students are given an opportunity to make up any examination, study, or work requirements that may be missed due to a religious observance, provided they notify their instructors no later than the academic drop deadline. For observances occurring before the drop deadline, notification is required at least two academic days in advance. Students may enter their observances in MySlice under Student Services/Enrollment/My Religious Observances/Add a Notification.

7.8 Health and Wellness

Mental health and overall well-being are significant predictors of academic success. As such it is essential that during your college experience you develop the skills and resources effectively to navigate stress, anxiety, depression, and other mental health concerns. Please familiarize yourself with the range of [resources](#) the Barnes Center provides and seek out support for mental health concerns as needed. Counseling services are available 24/7, 365 days, at 315-443-8000, and I encourage you to explore the resources available through the [Wellness Leadership Institute](#).